Eight Questions Families Ask When One Person Is Doing Most of the Caring

Plain answers to general questions, and when to take yours to a professional.

Families where one person does most of the caring tend to have the same handful of questions, and a good many of them never get said out loud. Here are eight, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about your husband or your family in particular. Where a question needs someone who knows you, the answer says who to ask.

1 Is it normal for one person to end up doing most of it?

It's common. AARP's planning guide for families says that in most families one person assumes the primary role, and the National Institute on Aging says it tends to be a spouse, or the child or sibling who lives closest. Common doesn't tell you whether it suits your family. The Institute suggests checking in with the person and the other caregivers regularly to make sure the current arrangement is still working for everyone, and looking at it doesn't commit anyone to changing it. [1] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know whether your husband needs more help than he has now. That takes someone who assesses him, and no guide can tell you.

2 How do I tell what has actually gotten harder?

Write the week down. List what you do for your husband in a typical week, small things included, and mark each task as new or changed in the last year, or not. Caregiving covers a lot of ground, from personal care and meals to keeping track of medications, driving to appointments and paying bills, and a list shows you which parts have grown. [3] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** what has gotten harder is his health, or what he can do for himself. Describe what you've seen to his doctor. The National Institute on Aging suggests a visit to a health care provider when you're concerned about a person's physical or mental health.

3 How do we find out which tasks nobody has really agreed to?

Sort the tasks into three piles: the ones where a person is named and you've talked about it, the ones you assume someone handles but have never discussed, and the ones that are nobody's yet. The Family Caregiver Alliance says families often don't think through who becomes the primary caregiver and what supporting roles the others will play, and its sample meeting agenda includes a written summary of what each person has agreed to. For the middle pile, a plain question is enough: “Are you still the one who calls in his refills?” [5] [6] [7]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** what's unclear is how a task is done, such as managing his medications at home, and not only who does it. The Family Caregiver Alliance says a nurse can answer questions about managing medications at home.

4 Why is it so hard to ask the kids for help?

It can be. The National Institute on Aging says accepting help isn't always easy: you may worry about being a burden, or feel uncomfortable admitting you can't do it all yourself. Its suggestions are to ask for small things at first, and to have a list of things that need doing and let the other person choose. The Family Caregiver Alliance adds that asking directly and specifically works better than hinting. [8] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've asked plainly and the conversation keeps going sideways. The Family Caregiver Alliance says even the healthiest families can sometimes use an objective professional, such as a social worker, to help them stay on the topic at hand.

5 My daughter thinks everything is fine, and I'm not sure it is. Which of us is right?

A guide can't weigh that, and the two of you don't have to settle it. Writing about families who share a parent's care, the Family Caregiver Alliance says differences in how people see what's needed are common, and that it's natural to take in the situation at different times and in different ways. It also says relatives may assume the main caregiver has everything covered, so they don't recognize the added responsibilities. Write down how each of you sees it, without choosing between them, and show her the week on paper. [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the two of you stay far apart on what your husband needs. The Family Caregiver Alliance says a physician, a social worker or a geriatric care manager can help a family establish what is real about a person's health and needs.

6 There's more than one thing we don't agree on. Which do we take up first?

That's the family's choice, and one is enough to start. The Family Caregiver Alliance recommends a narrow focus for each meeting and says it will probably be difficult to cover every issue in one. AARP's guide says to start small, with just one aspect of your concerns, and to try again if a first conversation doesn't go well. Keep the rest on a list of open issues so nothing is lost. [6] [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the family is divided on a big issue, such as a move or more support for your husband. The Family Caregiver Alliance says a neutral outside facilitator often helps, and that social workers, ministers and physicians can facilitate a family meeting or refer you to someone who can.

7 Should my husband be part of these conversations?

Yes. AARP's guide says a family caregiving plan must center on the wishes of the person receiving the care, and should never be made without that person's participation, knowledge and consent. The National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly. Write his concerns down in his own words, and keep them separate from what the family wants for him. [1] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're not sure how to bring him into the conversation in a way that works for him. Ask his doctor, or raise it with your care consultant.

8 Where do we take a concern the family can't answer?

It depends on the concern. For his health, the Family Caregiver Alliance suggests making a list of your most important concerns for the physician, and notes that many caregiving questions, such as personal care and managing medications at home, relate more to nursing than to medicine. The National Institute on Aging says larger medical practices often have a social worker on staff who may have suggestions about community services. To find resources in your area, the Eldercare Locator is at 800-677-1116. [7] [9] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't tell which kind of professional a concern belongs to. Ask any of them where it should go, or bring it to your care consultant.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about your husband or your family in particular, and it doesn't say whether your arrangement is working. Anything that depends on his health, what he can do, or your own health needs a professional who knows you.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions. The care interview is where the questions become about your husband and your family: it walks you through his needs and the help around him area by area, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
3. National Institute on Aging, Getting Started With Caregiving
4. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
7. Family Caregiver Alliance, Taking Care of YOU: Self-Care for Family Caregivers
8. National Institute on Aging, Taking Care of Yourself: Tips for Caregivers
9. National Institute on Aging, Taking Someone to a Doctor's Appointment: Tips for Caregivers